Arctic Sea Ice Is Shrinking and Getting Thinner

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The Arctic Ocean is covered by frozen seawater called **sea ice**. The ice grows in winter and shrinks in summer. **Satellites** have watched it since late 1978.

In 2026, the ice reached its smallest size on September 12. It covered about 4.6 million **square kilometers**. NASA and the National Snow and Ice Data Center say that tied for the 10th-lowest level on record. In March 2026, the winter ice tied March 2025 for the lowest winter peak ever recorded.

Over the past ten years, summer ice has stayed about the same instead of dropping fast. NASA researchers say more clouds blocked some sunlight. But the ice is still far below normal.

The ice is also getting younger and thinner, so it melts more easily. Scientists say rising **temperatures** are part of the cause. They think the Arctic could be nearly **ice-free** in summer at least once before 2050.

Word Treasure

sea ice -- Ice that forms when ocean water freezes.

Satellites -- Machines in space that circle Earth and take measurements.

square kilometers -- A unit for measuring how big an area is.

temperatures -- Measurements of how hot or cold something is.

ice-free -- Having no ice at all.

Background you need

The Arctic is the cold area around the North Pole, where the ocean is covered by floating ice for much of the year.

Bright ice reflects sunlight, while dark ocean water soaks up more heat.

Scientists compare each year's ice with many past years to find long-term changes.

Break it down

WHO: NASA, the National Snow and Ice Data Center and other scientists
WHAT: Arctic sea ice is shrinking and getting thinner
WHERE: The Arctic Ocean
WHY: Rising temperatures are part of the cause

Why it matters

Changes in Arctic ice affect polar animals and Earth's climate, which matters to everyone.

Test what you remember

1. **When did Arctic sea ice reach its smallest size in 2026?**
   - (A) September 12
   - (B) July 4
   - (C) January 1
   - (D) March 3
2. **Since when have satellites watched the Arctic ice?**
   - (A) Late 1978
   - (B) 1900
   - (C) Last year
   - (D) 2012
3. **What did NASA researchers say blocked some sunlight?**
   - (A) Mountains
   - (B) Clouds
   - (C) Birds
   - (D) Smoke
4. **How is the ice changing?**
   - (A) It is turning green
   - (B) It is getting younger and thinner
   - (C) It is moving to the desert
   - (D) It is getting much thicker
5. **About how big was the ice at its smallest in 2026?**
   - (A) 460 square kilometers
   - (B) 1 billion square kilometers
   - (C) 10 square kilometers
   - (D) 4.6 million square kilometers
6. **What do scientists think could happen before 2050?**
   - (A) A nearly ice-free summer
   - (B) The Arctic becomes a desert
   - (C) No more winters
   - (D) More ice than ever

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: B 4: B 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. NASA researchers: Say more clouds blocked some sunlight and helped slow summer melting.

2. Scientists: Say rising temperatures are part of the cause of the ice loss.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):